SCOPE AND SUBJECT MATTER OF IR

International Relation is a dynamic discipline. With the world fast changing in the face of globalization, along with the threats of fundamentalism, ethnicity and terrorism, ebbing state system, crisis in sovereignty of states, human rights, newer international regimes, the discipline has been forced to move beyond its traditional themes and incorporarte a 'new agenda' in its study.

Initially, the discipline devoted itself to the study of diplomatic history, foreign policies of states, international law, international organizations. Since the outbreak of the Second World War and in the years following it, the world was not only engulfed in a Cold War between the United States and the Soviet Union but it also witnessed the birth of many new states due to rapid decolonization, which led to an expansion of the scope of IR. As a result, new theories, and newer methodologies to study IR emerged. As in the 1960s and 1970s, when behaviouralism made a pathway into the study of IR, motives and behaviours of states as well as political leaders came to be studied. It is quite an extensive discipline embracing diplomatic history, international politics, international organization, international law, area studies, behaviour of states and their mutual relations, international trade and foreign policy. Its scope is still expanding and will expand in future too. As Frederick S. Dunn contends that the word 'scope' is ambiguous because it implies fixed boundary lines readily identifiable as a surveyor's mark. Therefore, he suggested that the "subject matter of international relations consists of whatever knowledge, from any sources, may be of assistance in meeting new international problems or understanding old ones".[30] IR scholars have never agreed on where the boundaries of their field lie.

Goldstein projects IR as a field of study focussing on:

1. Issue areas—diplomacy, war, trade relations, alliances, cultural exchanges, participation in international organizations, etc.
2. Conflict and cooperation in relationship among states concerning issue areas.
3. International security—questions of war and peace.